

Fishing as a livelihood, a way of life, or just a job: considering the complexity of “fishing communities” in research and policy

Delgado-Ramírez, Ota, Cisneros-Montemayor (2022). *Reviews in Fish Biology and Fisheries*.

Summary in My Own Words

- Authors draw from four case studies in northwest Mexico to summarize community members' relationships to fishing either as “livelihood”, a “way of life”, or a “job”.
- It is important to be specific when using words like ‘fishing community’ versus ‘local community’.
- While the distinction between the two can be subtle, the term ‘fishing community’ connotes a shared kinship between people that is based on cultural heritage and cosmogeny that is centered around fishing or the ocean, whereas a local community is a little more general in its connotation of what members share. Members of a ‘local community’ tend to share land, but aren’t necessarily linked as kin and tend to be more ‘heterogenous’ in terms of their cultural ties to the ocean, heritage, beliefs, and cultural traditions.
- A fishing community exists within a local community.
- Fishers that view fishing as just a job do not have strong ties to the ocean beyond a source of income.
- The authors present helpful examples and quotes from fishers who fish as a way of life, versus livelihood, versus just a job.

Methods

Ethnographic research in northwest Mexico, collected over two decades. Sonora sites visited yearly from 1998 to 2006, with intensive (2–4 week) field research in 2009 and 2018. In Baja California sites, extensive research was carried out yearly from 2012 to 2016, and intensive yearly from 2018 to 2021.

Key Points from the Introduction

- “Contextualizing the importance of historical and cultural factors in scoping community units beyond occupational or geographical characteristics is essential for identifying and addressing (in)equitable processes and outcomes in fisheries sectors, research, and management”
- **“... the versatility with which the notion of ‘fishing community’ is used is often confusing and sometimes problematic because of its undefined nature and fluid terminology (Brookfield et al., 2005)”**
- “Increased focused on fisheries management and policy but can lead to inequitable outcomes when recommendations lack nuance or social context.”
- “Published [fisheries] research rarely delves into social-ecological relationships, ...”
- “‘Exclusion by generalization’ risks further marginalization of individuals who have had historically little input into fisheries policy, like women, Indigenous fisheries, and fisheries without permits who may not locally be considered ‘illegal’.”

- “Community also commonly implies basic elements such as belonging, being together, and social interaction (Tjora and Scambler, 2020).”

Four Localities with Distinct Fishing Histories and Community Dynamics

• SPR *Ejido* Esteban Cantú in Ensenada

A vibrant, active *Ejido* space managed by 39 members (not including their family members at home). Some members fish regularly while others farm or lease their fishing rights to non-ejido members.

What is an *Ejido*? Land that is technically owned by the government but managed by the people and farmed in a common way. *Ejid*os came to be through a series of 20th-century land reforms intended to redistribute land from wealthy, private (and in most cases Spanish Creole) landlords to local farmers and agriculturalists. Notably, the concept of an ejido is based on Indigenous land practices that pre-date 16th century Spanish-Aztec contact. Rights to work the ejido, including the various parcels of land within it, are passed on through family lines and, for the most part, cannot be sold. (Want to learn more? The wiki on this is not bad! <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ejido>)

“These divers and fishers now mainly target red and purple urchin (*Mesocentrotus franciscanus*, *Strongylocentrotus purpuratus*), sea cucumber (*Parastichopus parvimensis*), starfish (*Pisaster* spp.), and fin-fishes.”

“Women primarily work in processing and sales, though some may work occasionally in capture fisheries, particularly for starfish. Nevertheless, when members of the SPR pass away, their “membership” is transferred to their wife, who generally hands it to a son to work in his father’s place.”

“The SPR has two management polygons for urchin capture of urchin, cucumber, and starfish. Members also have multi-use fragments of ejido land which is used in three main ways: 1) divers and active fishers dedicating their free time to low-impact tourism and/or beekeeping; 2) divers and fishers that are only active during urchin season (July to February) and that dedicate the rest of the year to agriculture and/or small-scale livestock care; and 3) inactive divers and fishers that lease their places in the SPR and are fully dedicated to agricultural and livestock work or another activity.”

“Although the SPR does not provide health care or a retirement pension system for its members, it can provide emergency funds, ...”

“*Ejidatarios* and neighbors have a daily relationship with the city of Ensenada, where shops, banks and government offices are located.”

• El Sauzal de Rodríguez in the Port of Ensenada

A fishing ‘company town’ developed in the 20th century based (then) on abalone and lobster production, now home to the majority of Baja California’s industrial fleet. The town was built alongside a school, a medical clinic, a baseball field, a number of homes for fishers, etc. It is now the *Manchuria* neighborhood the north of Ensenada proper. The neighborhood has grown

tremendously over the last century, now surrounded by seafood packing factories, aquaculture enterprises, manufacturing plants, and middle-class homes. Many of the people who live in El Sauzal are fishworkers of some sort but “The everyday life of these fish workers is ... blended within the larger social and residential context of a township that now has over 11 thousand inhabitants.”

“During the 1930s, Abelardo Rodríguez bought and installed abalone and lobster canneries in the north of the city of Ensenada in what is now El Sauzal de Rodríguez township.”

“In 1939, once the Ensenada-Tijuana highway was completed, connecting the region with California, the neighborhood became a growing hub of commercial activity. In addition to fishworkers, El Sauzal became home for longshoremen and shipbuilders working at the shipyard, thus comprising individuals from throughout the seafood value chain.”

“New residential neighborhoods are being developed for upper-middle income families, from which fishers and their families are totally excluded. However, many residents are still industrial fishers dedicated mainly to the sardine fishery (*Sardinops sagax*), as well as small-scale fishers and fishworkers engaged in fisheries for lobster, finfishes and sea urchin, and the packaging of marine products from both fisheries and aquaculture.”

“Concurrently with the expansion of industrial fisheries and their social influence, the contiguous *Aduana* (‘Customs,’ after the customs office in the port) neighborhood was developed by artisanal fishers and their families starting in the 1930s.”

“Nowadays, the *Aduana* is a marginalized neighborhood dealing with issues related to drug addiction and prostitution... Some have argued that issues of increased crime, drugs, and prostitution are a consequence of the embargo on tuna exports from Mexican fisheries imposed by the US in 1993; this bankrupted the entire industrial tuna fleet and caused a profound economic crisis from which the city continues to recover (Almaraz, 2018).”

• **Bahia de Kino in Sonora**

A 19th century fishing camp home to a mix of Indigenous Comca’ac fishers and within-country immigrant fishers that target a diverse list of species. Most of this area is managed by a large number of distinct fishing cooperatives. The town itself is relatively large, full of diverse people, host to a long history of fishing, and some long-standing disagreements / conflict between groups of fishers.

“Kino Viejo (or simply Kino) originated as a fishing camp at the end of the XIX century, established by fishers from Puerto Peñasco (known as ‘Rocky Point’ in the US) and Indigenous Comca’ac (Comca’ac is the ethnonym of this Indigenous group but they are also known as the Seri, the name given by Spanish colonizers) to take advantage of the local abundance of totoaba (*Cynoscion macdonaldi*).”

“In 1933, a local Lázaro Cárdenas Cooperative was created as an extension of its headquarters in Puerto Peñasco. In the 1940s, a local shark fishery developed due to the high demand for shark liver oil for nutritional purposes, but shark prices (and the fishery) declined once synthetic vitamins were developed, leaving the fishing site almost unpopulated.”

“The organization of fishing cooperatives and the proliferation of efficient outboard engines between 1965 and 1975 established Kino as a receptive place for national migrants from different

states of Mexico, generally coming for work in the agricultural lands of nearby Hermosillo (the capital city of Sonora),”

“During these years, groups of fishers from the southern state of Chiapas arrived while following shark migrations by land. These *chiapanecos* came to Kino and fished by associating with a local fishing permit holder... Other groups that later started to arrive for extended stays in Kino were the *lobeños*, from Puerto Lobos...”

“The *lobeños* targeted the same species as *kineño* fishers. In the 1990s, conflicts further intensified between the coastal population and new immigrants, ...”

“The current population of Bahia de Kino is about 6500 habitants (INEGI, 2020) and the fishing activity continues to diversify, with almost 50 known target species...”

“There are 32 registered cooperatives and 41 permit holders, 365 pangas, 459 fishers and 506 permits (Fernández et al., 2018). Although the town extends inland, the houses located closer to the beach are mostly of fisher families.”

“Women in particular also have a more active participation in fishing activities, managing the administration of some cooperatives and leading family cooperatives. Women commonly lead processing activities such as boiling crabs and removing and packing the flesh, filleting fish, and selling these products in the town or packaging them for transport to other markets.”

“Women also primarily work in a small local processing plant cleaning, peeling, and packing shrimp, and many are employed in the tourism sector of the town as receptionists, administrators, and cleaning and sales.”

“Kino Viejo can be defined as a fishing town, even though only about 20% of the population is occupied in fishwork...”

• Punta Chueca and El Desemboque de los Seri

This area is managed by the Comca’ac people under *ejido* rules but non-Comca’ac persons also fish here under person-to-person agreements. Fishers here fish primarily penshell and swimming crab. Comca’ac members of this community were subject to government-sanctioned attacks and cultural genocide throughout Spanish-colonial rule and thereafter by the Mexican government (1800s through 1900s) that reduced the overall size and financial resources of their community. This dark history continues to influence dynamics in the fishing community today, and relationships between “Comca’ac and outside fishers and traders are complex.”

“The Indigenous Comca’ac people have habited the central coast of the state of Sonora since the prehispanic era. The knowledge and use of ocean and desert resources are not only the base of their subsistence, but the core of their culture and cosmogony. Like other Indigenous peoples in northern Mexico, their population was organized in nomadic groups and diminished drastically during the colonial period.”

“The *ejido* El Desemboque and its annex Punta Chueca are the two main localities in which the Comca’ac peoples live, including 1200 persons (Hernández, 2018). This *ejido* includes Tiburón Island and the Infiernillo Channel, and the Comca’ac have exclusive legal rights to resource use in the island and channel.”

“The majority of the Comca’ac men agreed with these informal contracts, but some refused to allow outsiders to capture their resources (mainly penshell and swimming crab) inside their territory. This disagreement between Comca’ac people revived old conflicts associated with lineage and clan adscription and added to the difficulties in establishing their own Indigenous cooperatives.”

“The Comca’ac thus participate in daily subsistence and commercial fisheries that are still woven with cultural practices.”

“While Comca’ac women traditionally participated mainly in gleaning during low tides and in preparation of meals as outlined above, younger women have more recently begun engaging in commercial activities.”

“The Comca’ac people find themselves strongly linked to and partially dependent on outside forces, notably including Bahia de Kino and other outside fishers and buyers. For Comca’ac elders, the transformation of scallops, crabs, and other resources from their biocultural world and heritage into commodities, is only part of a domination by outsiders of Comca’ac territory, cosmogony, and culture.”

General Takeaways

“... most fishing communities are not self-sufficient anymore; even those retaining relatively more traditional practices often sell at least some catch to buy other products. These and other factors do not preclude the fact that such communities remain firmly rooted in their seascapes (Brookfield et al. 2005),”

“[A] ‘fishing community’ has a set of values, a tradition, knowledge, referents, and pride that give the members cohesion and a desire to transmit this to their children. In such communities, we can find a sense of unity that transcends the personal and the fishing activity itself, and it is common to find kinship relations between their members. In practice, this may mean that programs aiming to support alternative livelihoods in such communities may not have the uptake that economics-based assumptions may anticipate.”

“Conversely, a ‘local community’ is formed by a geographically-bounded area or neighborhood (e.g., Ensenada-El Sauzal)... A local community is nonetheless more heterogeneous than a fishing community and tends to self-locate and identify as a geopolitical and administrative unit: a locality, a township, even an island.”

“Throughout our case studies, the otherness between fishing communities is not necessarily based on physical locality but is often based on competition for fishing resources (for example, the different welcomes experienced by *chiapanecos* in Kino Viejo compared to *lobeños*, based on their overlap with locals’ target species). Following from our key argument, proposed fisheries management or policy actions would clearly require a consideration of these various embedded groupings to ensure that they are appropriate in scale and target population.”

Table 1 Framing approach to understand and differentiate community relationships with capture fisheries and fishwork

Fishing as...	Worldview	Daily life	Income
Way of life	Individual and group identity is fully enveloped within fishwork. In the case of Indigenous communities in particular, fisheries and seascapes are often integral to cosmogony (creation mythologies)	Daily routines and individual occupations and places within community revolve around fishwork	Fishwork is often the primary (or only) source of income, but the practice of fishing and the relationships it underpins are seen as more important than the income itself
Livelihood	Fishwork is often a part of more diverse ways of life, but the practice of fishing and experience of seascapes contribute to overall worldviews	Daily routines largely revolve around fishwork, but also incorporate other occupations and relationships	Fishwork is often the primary, but not only, source of income
Job	Fishwork provides unique experiences that may inform but do not underpin worldviews	Fishwork structures routines during working hours	Fishwork is often a seasonal or sporadic source of income (that can still be significant)

Columns indicate bounding questions regarding the relative importance of fishwork in framing worldviews, structuring daily activities, and contributing to income. Rows include the types of communities identified for cases in this study, with table contents providing further context for each

Conclusions

“First, it is important to specify the type of grouping that underlies our bounding and use of community in research. Drawing from our case studies, this could include, for example, a local or island community (physical location), a community of fishworkers (shared practice), a joint-access community (shared legal status, e.g., an ejido), or an Indigenous community (Indigenous or ethnic group)...

“Second, we must be clear about the motivation and depth of relationships of individuals in a community with the practice of fishing. Here this is typologized as way of life, livelihood, or a job, but researchers must consider these motivations (and boundings) in the context of their own research areas.”

“As an entry point into these critical perspectives on a particular locality, guiding questions include whether fisheries and fishwork 1) structure daily-life activities; 2) inspire and frame fundamental worldviews; and 3) represent the primary source of employment and income.”